



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ivy Classical Academy
School Website: <https://ivyclassical.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Ivy Classical Academy, Prattville (Alabama, 36066) presents a largely classical profile across Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community, with a notable exception in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. Public materials emphasize formation, virtue, and a content-rich liberal arts approach, anchored by Hillsdale-affiliated curricula and a commitment to virtue-driven civic education. Evidence includes explicit mission language about training minds and improving hearts through moral character and civic virtue, and a public emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable. The school also highlights Socratic-style pedagogy, memory-based recitation practices, a strong liberal-arts curriculum (grammar-logic-rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation), teacher-expert instruction, and an active Parent Service Organization. However, the materials reviewed do not reveal explicit liturgical or theological grounding, worship practices, or a liturgical communal rhythm, which is a hallmark asserted by some classical models.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): NOT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mission emphasizes moral character and civic virtue rather than explicit theology or liturgical life; no overt liturgical practices are described in the public materials. See mission statement language emphasizing moral character and civic virtue.
 - Positive indicators observed: virtue, moral character, formation (present in mission); general emphasis on transcendent aims appears more in Element 2 language (truth/goodness/beauty) than explicit theological grounding.
 - Rationale: Without explicit theological grounding or liturgical communal practices in public-facing materials, Element 1 falls short of a full Religious & Metaphysical Foundation with transcendent moral realism or liturgical life as defined in the classical rubric.
- Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mission to train minds and improve hearts through a content-rich classical education with moral character and civic virtue; graduates described as exemplary citizens guided by virtues. The public materials foreground formation of character in harmony with classical aims.
 - Positive keyword indicators observed: formation, virtue, character, wisdom, moral imagination, liberal education, eternal aims (truth/goodness/beauty) as guiding ideals. The "What is Classical Education?" articulation explicitly anchors truth, goodness, and beauty as real.
 - Why this rating: The school foregrounds formation of virtue and wisdom as the telos of education, not merely job-readiness, and identifies truth/goodness/beauty as guiding ideals.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Curriculum is explicitly framed around liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), integration across history, literature, and the sciences, and engagement with the Great Books / Great Conversation through Hillsdale Barney Charter pedagogy. Curriculum maps and Path-based curriculum emphasize well-rounded, interconnected study.
 - Positive keyword indicators observed: liberal arts (grammar/logic/rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation, history integrated across disciplines, virtuous inquiry, memorization/recitation components, interdisciplinary harmony.

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- Why this rating: The explicit Trivium/Quadrivium framing, integration across disciplines, and emphasis on Great Books align strongly with classical curriculum criteria.
 - Element 4 (Pedagogy): CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Public materials describe teacher-led, content-rich instruction with Socratic seminars, guided discussions, and high-level discourse; lower-school practices include memorization and chanting as memory supports; upper-school rhetoric and debate opportunities are noted.
 - Positive keyword indicators observed: Socratic dialogue/seminars, rhetoric training, memorization/recitation, disciplined dialogue, formation through discussion, and the incorporation of memory work. Fine Arts notes emphasize singing/memory to reinforce learning.
 - Why this rating: A mix of Socratic seminars, logic/rhetoric emphasis, and memory-based pedagogy concords with classical teaching methods; sightings of higher-level rhetoric and public-speaking opportunities reinforce the classical pedagogy signal.
 - Element 5 (Faculty): CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Founding/faculty-centric communications emphasize a team of well-educated educators; emphasis on virtue-driven mentorship; staff and leadership are highlighted (head of school, deans, etc.), with a living-curriculum notion and a focus on teacher modeling of virtue.
 - Positive keyword indicators observed: model teachers, living curriculum, mentors, virtuous exemplars, teacher-scholars, and a culture of collegiality. The site references the Head of School, deans of curriculum and instruction, and a cadre of founding faculty.
 - Why this rating: Public materials present a deliberate focus on teachers as exemplars and core of the school's educational mission, consistent with classical faculty expectations.
 - Element 6 (Parents & Community): CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Active partnership with families via a Parent Service Organization (PSO), parent involvement in governance and volunteer opportunities, and explicit calls for parental engagement in curriculum nights, book studies, and campus visits. The school positions parents as co-educators and welcomes regular family involvement.
 - Positive keyword indicators observed: partnership with families, parent formation, household rhythms, home-school collaboration, living tradition in the family, parent formation, parental engagement, open campus, and community support.
 - Why this rating: The school explicitly treats parents as co-teachers and invites broad family involvement, consistent with classical-community expectations.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — NOT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mission emphasizes moral character and civic virtue; no explicit theology or liturgical practice described in public materials.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive signals include virtue, character, moral imagination; no clear theological or liturgical indicators in the public materials. Estimated keywords present: 3–4 positive vs 0 explicit negative on theology/liturgy (based on the available content).
 - Why this rating: The classical formation signals are present in virtue and moral aims, but explicit theological grounding or liturgical life is not evidenced in public content.
- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mission emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom; public articulation of truth/goodness/beauty as real and knowable; the aim is formation, not mere information.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include formation, virtue, truth, goodness, beauty, liberal education; no explicit negative indicators in the public materials for this category. Estimated keywords present: 4–5 positive vs 0 negative.
 - Why this rating: Clear telos aligned with classical paideia and the real-knowable-truth framework.
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Liberal arts emphasis (grammar, logic, rhetoric), integration across history, literature, sciences, and the Great Books/Great Conversation framework via Hillsdale Barney Charter; curriculum maps show cross-disciplinary integration.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, Great Conversation, history in curriculum, harmony of subjects; no indicated negative signals in

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- public materials. Estimated keywords present: 5–6 positive vs 0 negative.
 - Why this rating: Strong alignment with classical curriculum principles.
 - Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Socratic seminars in classrooms; teacher-led, content-rich instruction; memorization/recitation as memory-work; upper-school rhetoric and public speaking; restfulness and contemplative elements present in some materials; integration of memory and chant in lower-school pedagogy.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include Socratic dialogue, scholé/restful learning, memorization/recitation, formation through imitation; no clear negative signals in public materials. Estimated keywords present: 5–7 positive vs 0–1 negative signals.
 - Why this rating: The pedagogy closely mirrors classical methods across grade levels.
 - Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Founding faculty language, leadership structure (Head of School, Deans), mentor-like faculty culture; living curriculum and model-teacher ethos highlighted.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include model teachers, living curriculum, mentor-like faculty; limited explicit negative signals. Estimated keywords present: 3–4 positive vs 0 negative.
 - Why this rating: The public materials describe a faculty-led, virtue-guided, mentorship-focused approach consistent with classical norms.
 - Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Active PSO, parental involvement, partnerships with families, parent formation, and open-campus welcoming stance.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include partnership with families, parent formation, home-school collaboration, community support; no negative signals in public materials. Estimated keywords present: 4–5 positive vs 0 negative.
 - Why this rating: Strong alignment with classical expectations of family involvement and community partnership.

Aggregate assessment: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - The school demonstrates robust alignment with classical education in Categories 2–6, with clear curriculum, pedagogy, faculty culture, and community engagement consistent with classical aims. Element 1 shows virtue-focused formation but lacks explicit theological or liturgical grounding in public materials. Taken together, the overall profile is best described as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle (needle-moving changes to reach CLASSICAL across all categories) - Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): - Add explicit language and practices around theological grounding or liturgical rhythm that align with the “Liturgical and Communal Practices” criterion (even if non-denominational or ecumenical). For example: - A formal statement of philosophical/theological grounding (e.g., “truth, goodness, beauty as real and knowable; sacred order; Logos/metaphysical truths”). - Regular liturgical or communal practices (e.g., morning reflection, seasonal liturgies, or sacred music traditions tied to the curriculum). - Rationale: This would convert NOT CLASSICAL signals into a solid match for the Religious & Metaphysical Foundations category, strengthening the aggregate classical profile.

- Optional enhancements (beyond needle-moving changes):
 - Explicitly foreground Great Conversations and Great Books more explicitly in marketing materials, with sample course sequences showing direct engagement with foundational texts.
 - Consider a formal articulation of a “theology/moral philosophy” strand at the high-school level to reinforce the integration of belief, virtue, and reason within the curriculum.
- The concrete changes above would move more categories into CLASSICAL without sacrificing the school’s current strengths.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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